



Sense by Barclays

Summary

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KEY INSIGHTS

BARCLAYS

Barclays remains one of the most recognised and trusted banking brands in the UK, benefiting from a long-standing reputation, strong infrastructure, and financial credibility. However, among graduate audiences, the brand is often perceived as more traditional and less intuitive compared to digital-first competitors such as Monzo, Revolut, and Starling.

While graduates associate Barclays with stability and security, many younger consumers increasingly prioritise simplicity, speed, and low-effort digital experiences when choosing a bank. This creates a perception gap where Barclays is trusted, but not always seen as the most relevant option for everyday financial management.

SHIFTING GRADUATE EXPECTATIONS

The graduate banking market is increasingly shaped by digital behaviour and financial uncertainty. Graduates are entering a life stage associated with rent, budgeting, student debt, and wider financial pressure, increasing demand for tools that reduce stress and simplify money management.

At the same time, app-based banks have redefined expectations around:

- Real-time notifications
- Frictionless onboarding
- Spending insights and budgeting tools
- Fast, mobile-first experiences

As a result, graduates are no longer comparing Barclays only with traditional banks, but with fintech platforms that integrate seamlessly into daily life.

STRATEGIC OPPORTUNITY

These insights highlight a clear opportunity for Barclays to reposition itself as a simpler, more supportive, and digitally relevant financial partner for graduates.

Rather than competing solely on overdrafts or traditional banking features, Barclays can differentiate itself by combining:

- The trust and stability of a legacy bank
- The intuitive experience and usability associated with fintech platforms
- Personalised digital engagement and behaviour-driven rewards

This strategic direction forms the foundation of Sense by Barclays, a campaign-led experience designed to make banking feel clearer, easier, and more relevant for graduates navigating financial independence.

CAMPAIGN RATIONALE

The research highlights a clear shift in graduate expectations, where banking is increasingly judged by simplicity, convenience, and everyday usability rather than traditional financial features alone.

While Barclays benefits from strong trust and brand recognition, there is an opportunity to reposition the brand as more intuitive, supportive, and digitally relevant for younger audiences.

This creates space for a more personalised and low-effort banking experience that aligns with the behaviours and financial pressures faced by modern graduates.

SWOT ANALYSIS



STRENGTHS

- **Established Trust**
 - a trusted bank with long understanding reputation.
- **Robust Infrastructure**
 - Online/Mobile Banking are already secure & functional.
- **Clear Value Proposition**
 - “Sense” directly addressing frustration of students facing low effort choices
- **Defined Tangible Benefits**
 - highlights specific practical outcomes.



WEAKNESSES

- **Negative Brand Perception**
 - Banks being complex, traditional in graduates POV.
- **High User Effort**
 - current system requires users to "interpret information," "decide what matters".
- **Transactional Focus**
 - Current banking is “task-based” rather than intuitive or outcome oriented.



OPPORTUNITIES

- **Perception Gap**
 - Specific opening to win over graduates who value “simpler & easy” app based experiences
- **Communication Simplicity**
 - Practical outcomes benefits to make it sensible choice for graduates
- **Targeting Non Barclays Users**
 - consideration among graduates who did not previously hold a Barclays student account.



THREATS

- **Agile Competitors**
 - App-based banks are increasingly favored because they are easy to use.
- **Competitor Graduate Accounts**
 - traditional banks are also competing for the same "over 18" UK graduate demographic.
- **Graduate Decision Fatigue**
 - Campaign itself feels effort heavy & may fail to break through mental pressure for students

THE BIG IDEA

THE PROBLEM

Graduates are entering adulthood during a period of rising living costs, financial pressure, and digital overload. While traditional banks are trusted, they are often perceived as complex, transactional, and disconnected from the everyday needs of younger consumers.

At the same time, fintech platforms have reshaped expectations by offering fast, intuitive, and low-effort digital experiences.

THE IDEA

“Sense by Barclays” repositions banking as a personalised financial companion rather than simply a place to store money.

By combining intelligent insights, behaviour-driven rewards, and proactive support, the campaign transforms everyday banking into an experience that feels more supportive, relevant, and emotionally connected to graduate lifestyles.

HOW IT WORKS

Personalised Financial Guidance

The experience uses behavioural and spending data to deliver tailored insights that help graduates better understand and manage their finances.

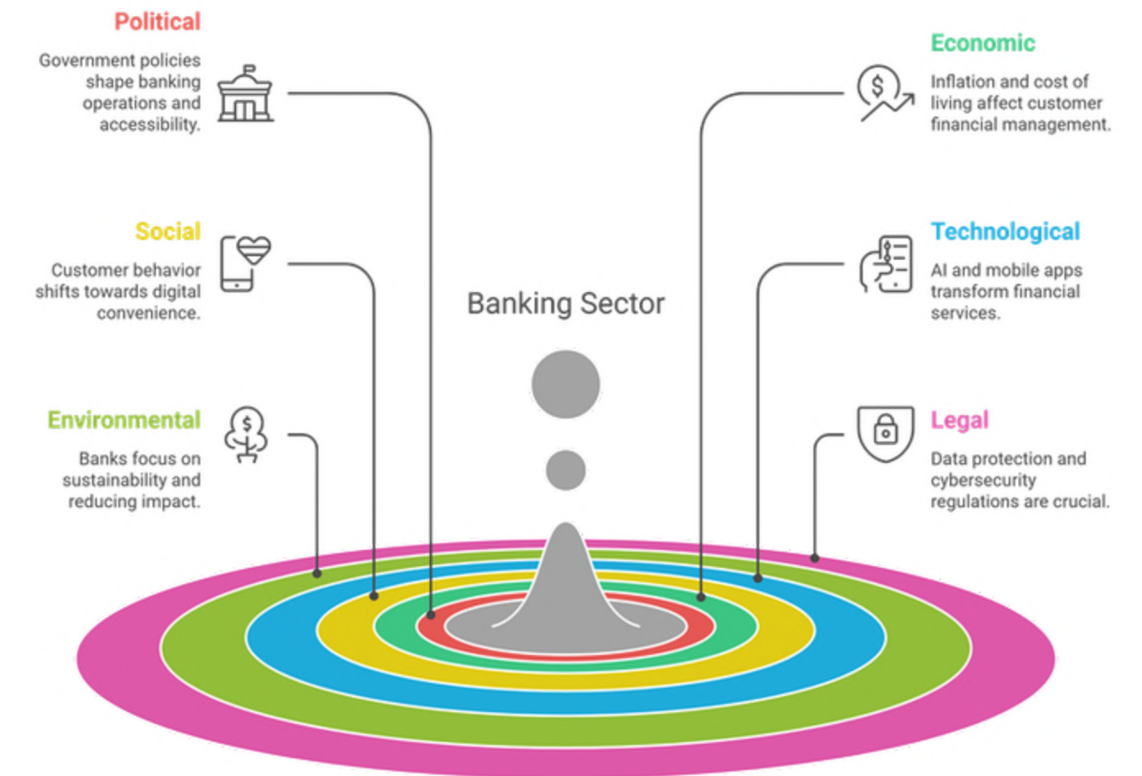
Proactive Support

Rather than waiting for users to seek help, the platform provides timely notifications, recommendations, and reminders that reduce financial stress and encourage positive habits.

Continuous Engagement

Ongoing personalisation and low-effort interactions create a more intuitive banking experience, encouraging graduates to remain engaged and build long-term loyalty over time.

PESTEL ANALYSIS



STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT

The campaign strategy extends beyond improving the user experience alone and responds directly to wider changes shaping the banking sector. Shifts in consumer behaviour, financial pressure, digital transformation, and growing expectations around personalisation have significantly influenced how graduates interact with financial services.

By aligning with these wider technological, economic, and social trends, the campaign positions Barclays as a more adaptive, intuitive, and digitally relevant financial brand for modern graduate audiences.

TARGET MARKET

UNDERSTANDING THE DIGITAL-FIRST GRADUATE

The target audience for the campaign focuses on graduates and young professionals aged 18–25 who are entering financial independence for the first time. This demographic largely consists of Generation Z consumers, a group strongly influenced by digital experiences, mobile convenience, and personalised online services. Generation Z audiences are highly connected through social media and spend significant time engaging with digital platforms daily. As a result, they increasingly expect brands, including banks, to provide fast, intuitive, and low-effort experiences that integrate naturally into their lifestyles.

In the banking sector, this audience is more likely to compare traditional banks with digital-first competitors such as Monzo, Revolut, and Starling, which are perceived as simpler, more modern, and easier to use. Features such as real-time notifications, spending insights, budgeting tools, and frictionless onboarding have become key expectations rather than added benefits. At the same time, many graduates face financial pressure linked to rent, student debt, budgeting, and rising living costs. This creates demand for banking experiences that feel supportive, personalised, and accessible rather than overly complex or transactional.

To better understand these behaviours and expectations, primary research was conducted through an online survey distributed to university students and recent graduates. The survey explored attitudes towards traditional banking, digital banking preferences, financial concerns, and the features participants valued most in a banking experience.

The findings directly informed the development of the “Sense by Barclays” campaign and the target persona presented below.

SURVEY FINDINGS:

Survey Insight	Key Finding
Most valued banking feature	Easy-to-use mobile app
Preferred banking experience	Fast, low-effort, and mobile-first
Main financial concerns	Budgeting, rent, and student debt
Perception of fintech banks	More modern, intuitive, and convenient
Perception of traditional banks	Trusted, but often seen as more complex
Features graduates expect	Spending insights, budgeting tools, and real-time notifications
Key motivation for switching banks	Better digital experience and usability
Importance of rewards	Cashback and personalised rewards increase engagement



PERSONA

EMILY CARTER

The Digital-First Graduate

“ I want banking to be simple, stress-free and work around my life. ”

Profile:

- 22 years old
- Final-year university student / recent graduate
- Lives in a rented apartment in a UK city
- Uses both a traditional bank and fintech apps such as Monzo or Revolut
- Frequently manages money through mobile banking rather than physical branches

Mindset & Behaviour:

Emily values simplicity, speed, and convenience when managing her finances. She prefers digital-first experiences that feel intuitive and low-effort, especially when dealing with everyday financial tasks such as budgeting, rent payments, and tracking spending. Although she sees Barclays as trustworthy and established, she also perceives traditional banks as more complicated and less modern compared to fintech alternatives. This reflects a wider perception gap identified in the survey responses.

Banking Habits:

- Checks banking apps daily
- Relies on spending notifications and real-time updates
- Prefers mobile-first experiences over branch visits
- Uses fintech apps for budgeting and money tracking
- Expects onboarding and account management to be fast and frictionless

CONTENT STRATEGY

CAMPAIGN OBJECTIVE

Our strategy aims to increase awareness and engagement with the Barclays Graduate Account among students and recent graduates by delivering clear, relatable, and digitally focused content. The strategy focuses on simplifying banking, promoting financial confidence, and positioning Barclays as a trusted and modern banking solution for graduates.

CONTENT THEMES

Content Theme	Purpose	Example Content
Financial Confidence	Help graduates manage money independently	Budgeting tips, salary management videos
Real Graduate Experiences	Build trust and relatability	“My First Year at Barclays” stories
Digital Banking Simplicity	Showcase easy-to-use banking tools	Spending insights, app tutorials
Career & Graduate Support	Promote Barclays Graduate Scheme	Career advice, graduate success stories
Lifestyle & Everyday Banking	Connect banking with graduate lifestyle	Rent payments, savings, daily spending

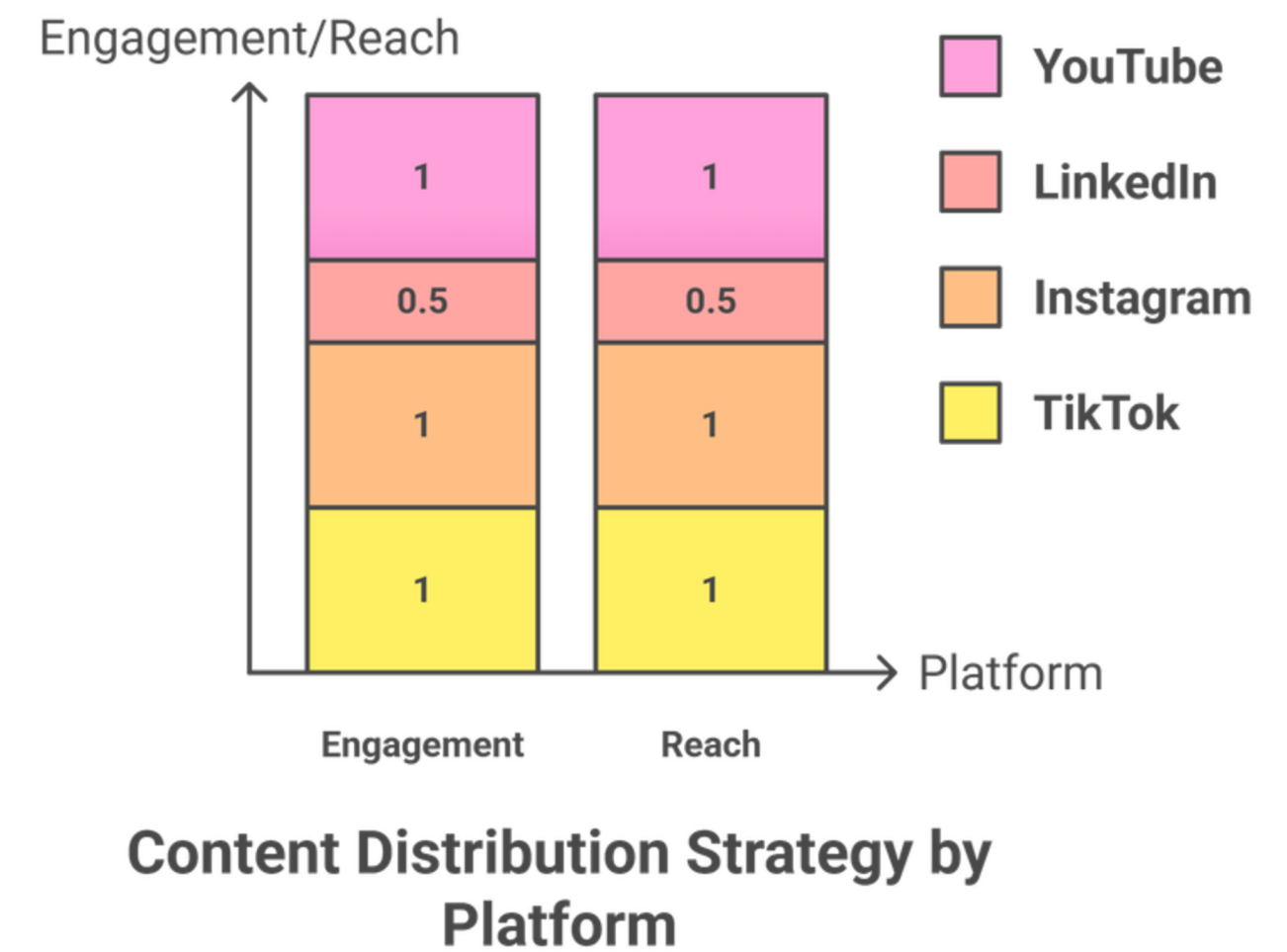
CONTENT DISTRIBUTION STRATEGY

Platform	Content Type	Purpose
TikTok	Short-form videos, trends, relatable graduate content	Increase engagement & reach
Instagram	Reels, stories, infographics	Visual storytelling & interaction
LinkedIn	Professional graduate stories & career advice	Career-focused communication
YouTube	Longer explainers & testimonial videos	Educational and informative content
Email Marketing	Personalised graduate offers & updates	Retention and direct communication

It also adopts a digital-first approach designed to engage graduates through relatable, informative, and interactive content. The strategy emphasises financial confidence, simplicity in banking, and real graduate experiences to strengthen audience trust and brand relatability.

Content is distributed across platforms frequently used by young adults, including TikTok, Instagram, LinkedIn, and YouTube, ensuring effective audience reach and engagement. Through a combination of short form videos, user-generated content, graduate testimonials, and educational banking content.

The campaign aims to position Barclays as a modern, accessible, and supportive financial institution for graduates transitioning into professional life.



BUDEGTING ALLOCATION

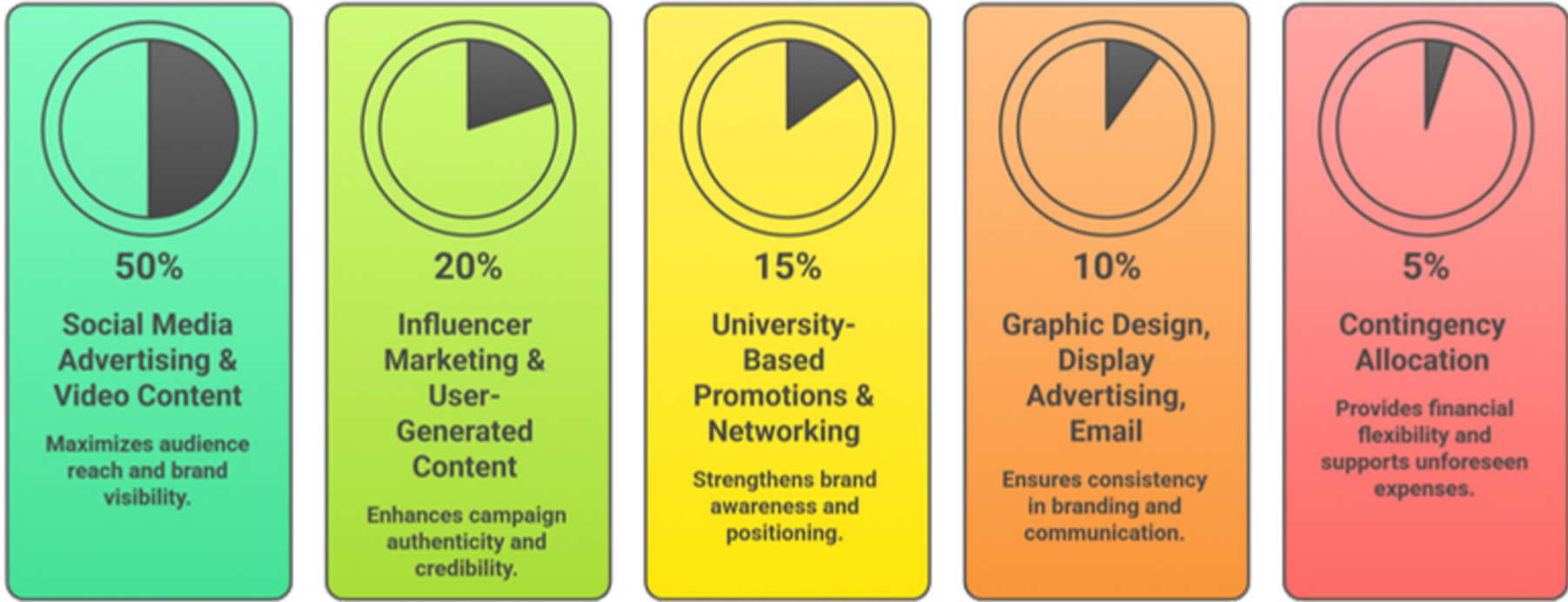
Campaign Activity	Purpose	Budget Allocation	Estimated Cost (£)
Social Media Advertising	Paid ads on TikTok, Instagram, LinkedIn & YouTube	30%	£3,300
Video Content Production	Creating short-form videos & app demonstrations	20%	£2,200
Influencer & UGC Campaign	Student influencers & graduate creators	12%	£1,320
University Campus Promotions	Posters, digital screens & leaflets	10%	£1,100
Networking Events & Webinars	Graduate networking sessions & online events	13%	£1,430
Graphic Design & Branding	Campaign visuals, banners & social creatives	6%	£660
Email & Display Advertising	Email campaigns and digital display ads	5%	£550
Contingency Fund	Unexpected or additional campaign costs	4%	£440

Our campaign adopts a predominantly digital marketing approach in response to the media consumption behaviours of graduates and young professionals, who actively engage with online platforms such as TikTok, Instagram, LinkedIn, and YouTube. Consequently, a substantial proportion of the campaign budget is allocated toward social media advertising and video content production in order to maximise audience reach, brand visibility, and consumer engagement within the graduate market segment.

Furthermore, investment in influencer marketing and user-generated content is intended to enhance campaign authenticity and credibility. Research suggests that peer recommendations and relatable experiences significantly influence the attitudes and decision-making processes of younger consumers. Therefore, incorporating graduate success stories and student influencers enables Barclays to establish stronger emotional connections with its target audience.

The budget also allocates resources toward university-based promotions and networking events to facilitate direct interaction with students during critical transition periods before and after graduation. These activities aim to strengthen brand awareness and reinforce Barclays' positioning as a supportive and accessible financial institution for graduates. In addition, funding is assigned to graphic design, display advertising, and email marketing to ensure consistency in branding and communication across all campaign channels. Finally, a contingency allocation has been included to provide financial flexibility and support the effective management of unforeseen campaign-related expenses.

Sense by Barclays" Campaign Budget Allocation



The campaign prioritizes digital channels and influencer marketing to reach young professionals and graduates.

CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR & FINANCIAL REALITY

CHANGING GRADUATE EXPECTATIONS

Financial Pressure

Digital Expectations

Loyalty Through Support

Budgeting stress, rent costs, uncertainty

Fast, intuitive, low-effort digital experiences

Ongoing guidance, not one-time products

BIG INSIGHT

Graduates are no longer choosing banks based solely on overdrafts or traditional financial products. Decision-making is increasingly influenced by usability, convenience, emotional reassurance, and the ability of a bank to support everyday financial life.

This creates a strong opportunity for Barclays to reposition itself as a more supportive, digitally relevant, and experience-led financial brand.

SHIFTING BANKING PRIORITIES

Graduate audiences increasingly expect banking experiences to feel intuitive, supportive, and integrated into their daily routines. As digital-first competitors continue reshaping expectations around convenience and usability, traditional banks face growing pressure to move beyond transactional relationships and deliver more personalised, low-effort experiences.

This behavioural shift highlights the importance of combining financial functionality with continuous engagement, emotional reassurance, and everyday relevance.



Banks win when they stop selling products and start solving financial lives.

TRADITIONAL BANKING VS GRADUATE EXPECTATIONS

Traditional Banking	Graduate Expectations
Product-focused	Experience-focused
Reactive support	Proactive guidance
Generic communication	Personalised insights
Transactional relationships	Continuous engagement
Complex systems	Simple experiences

OPPORTUNITIES & STRATEGIC TAKEAWAY

OPPORTUNITIES

Barclays benefits from strong trust and brand recognition, creating a valuable opportunity to attract and retain graduate audiences as they begin building financial independence and long term financial stability. There is also significant potential to engage graduates who did not previously open a Barclays student account by offering experiences and incentives that better align with their lifestyles and expectations.

The Blue Rewards programme already provides ongoing value through monthly benefits that encourage repeat engagement and continued account usage. However, the rapid growth of fintech platforms has significantly reshaped expectations around digital banking, with graduates increasingly expecting smooth, intuitive, and low effort experiences across mobile and online platforms. Traditional incentives such as large overdrafts are becoming less influential within the graduate market. Instead, younger audiences are increasingly drawn towards meaningful financial support, lifestyle focused benefits, smarter saving tools, and personalised financial guidance.

As a result, Barclays has an opportunity to reposition itself beyond transactional banking and become a more supportive, experience led financial partner that helps graduates navigate everyday financial life while building long term customer loyalty.

STRATEGIC TAKEAWAY

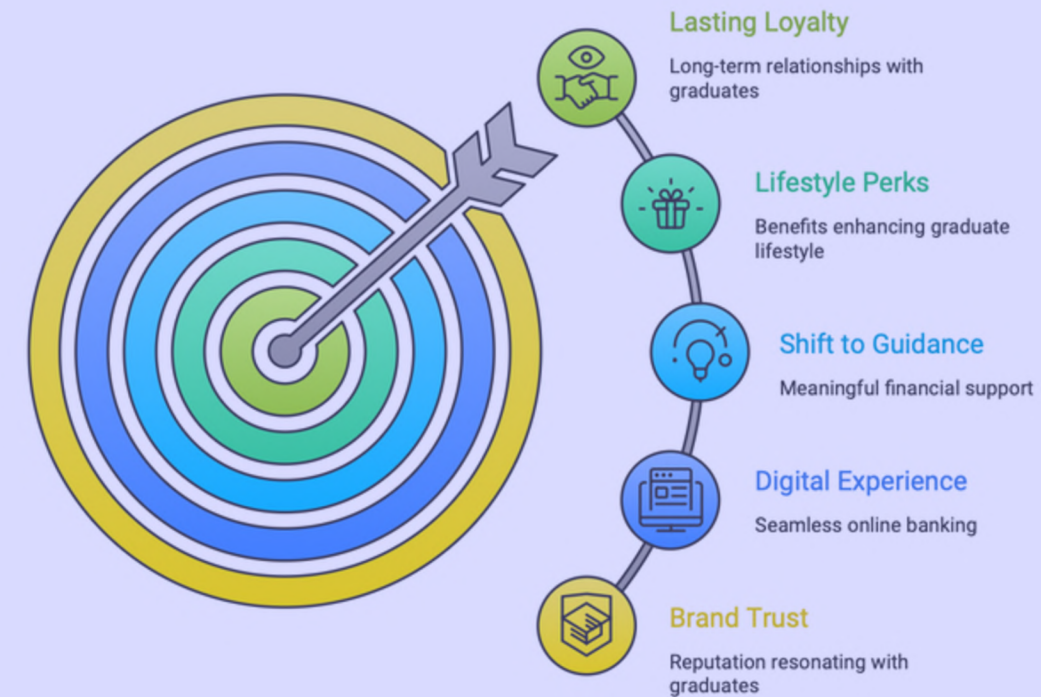
Barclays still carries a lot of credibility, and people trust the name. But let's be honest, graduates want more than old-school banking now. They look at Monzo or Starling and, right away, the appeal is obvious apps that are simple, smart budgeting tools, and features that actually fit how they manage money.

Traditional features such as overdrafts and customary benefits have lost their effectiveness. What really matters for grads are things like easy-to-use budgeting tools, flexible savings options, real advice tailored to them, and digital services that actually make life easier. Fintech brands have changed what people expect; everything's more convenient and feels personal. If you want graduates to stick around, you need to deliver that.

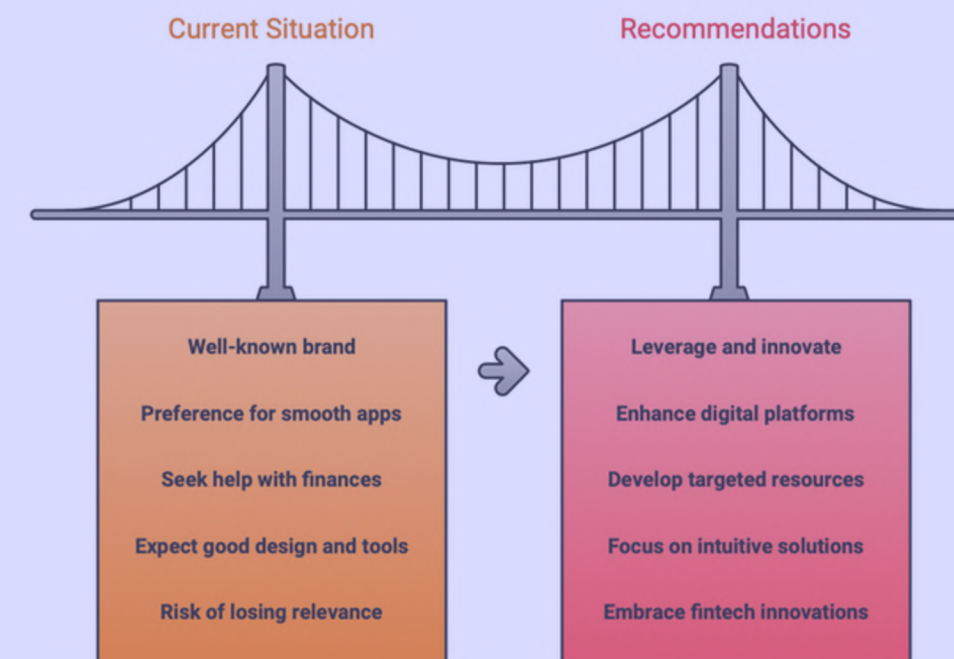
Barclays has a real opportunity. If it ramps up its digital side and actually focuses on the things grads face every day, it can show it's more than just another big bank. That's how Barclays stays relevant and connects with the younger crowd in a fintech driven world.

Long-term graduate loyalty is increasingly driven by digital relevance, financial guidance, and everyday usability rather than traditional banking incentives alone.

Barclays' Graduate Customer Attraction Strategy



Barclays' Adaptation to Evolving Graduate Banking Preferences



CHANNEL STRATEGY

The Barclays Graduate Scheme campaign uses a digital-first marketing strategy supported by strong offline promotion and networking experiences to connect with students and recent graduates during key career decision periods.

DIGITAL CHANNELS

The campaign focuses on platforms such as LinkedIn, Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube to deliver:

- Short-form career content
- Graduate success stories
- Interactive posts and videos
- Email campaigns, app notifications, and display ads

These channels help Barclays engage graduates in spaces they already use daily while reinforcing the campaign message: “Because it makes sense.”

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OFFLINE CHANNELS

Although digital-first, the campaign also uses physical touchpoints to increase awareness and credibility. These include:

- Posters and flyers in universities
- Digital signage in career centres
- Bus and building advertisements
- Pamphlets and newspaper promotions
- Recommendations from university career advisors
- Street promotional materials

These offline channels strengthen visibility and direct students toward the Barclays careers website, graduate events, and application opportunities.

EXPERIMENTAL NETWORKING EVENTS

The campaign also introduces networking-based experiential marketing to create direct connections between Barclays and graduates. Activities include:

- Career networking events
- Virtual meetups and webinars
- Alumni-led discussions
- Recruiter Q&A sessions

These experiences allow students to interact with Barclays professionals, gain career insights, and understand real employee experiences. This humanises the brand, builds trust, and positions Barclays as a supportive and accessible employer.

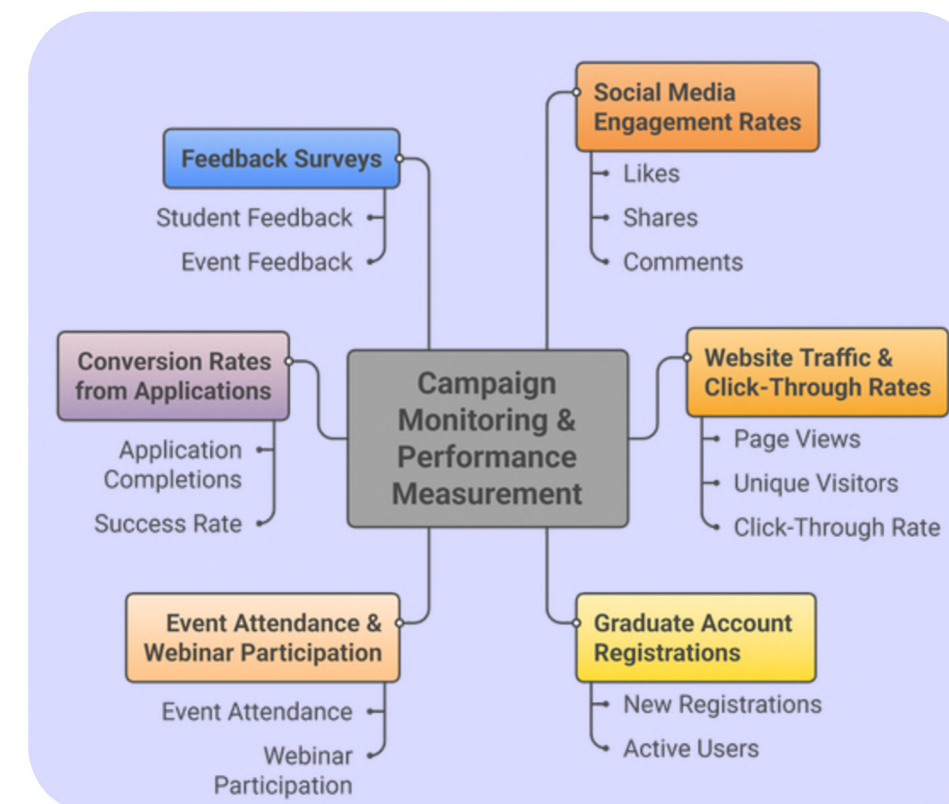
A/B TESTING STRATEGY

To improve campaign performance, Barclays can use A/B testing across digital platforms

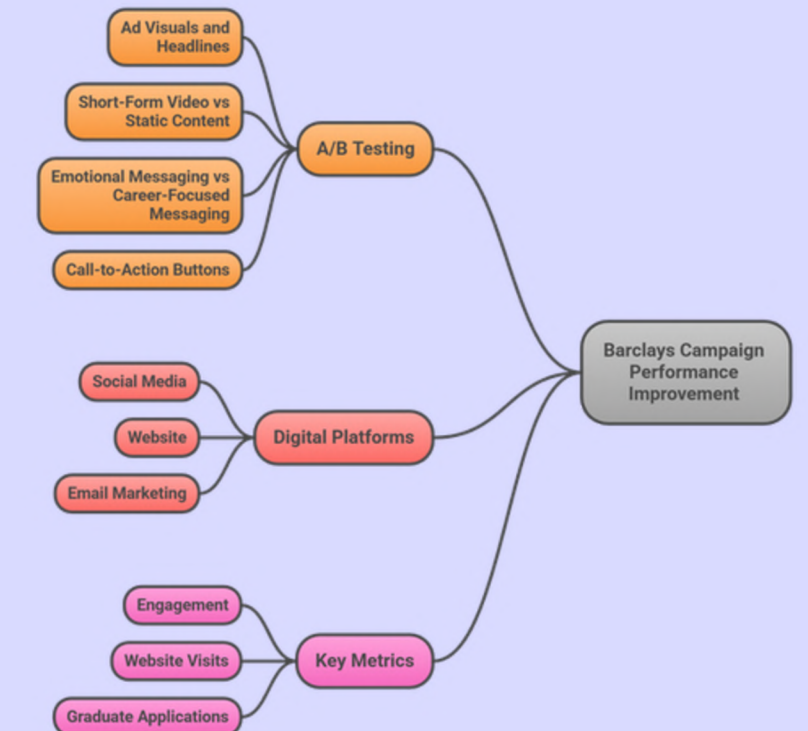
- Different ad visuals and headlines
- Short-form video vs static content
- Emotional messaging vs career-focused messaging
- Different call-to-action buttons such as “Apply Now” or “Start Your Future”

This helps identify which content generates the highest engagement, website visits, and graduate applications.

CAMPAIGN MONITORING



Barclays Campaign Performance Improvement through A/B Testing



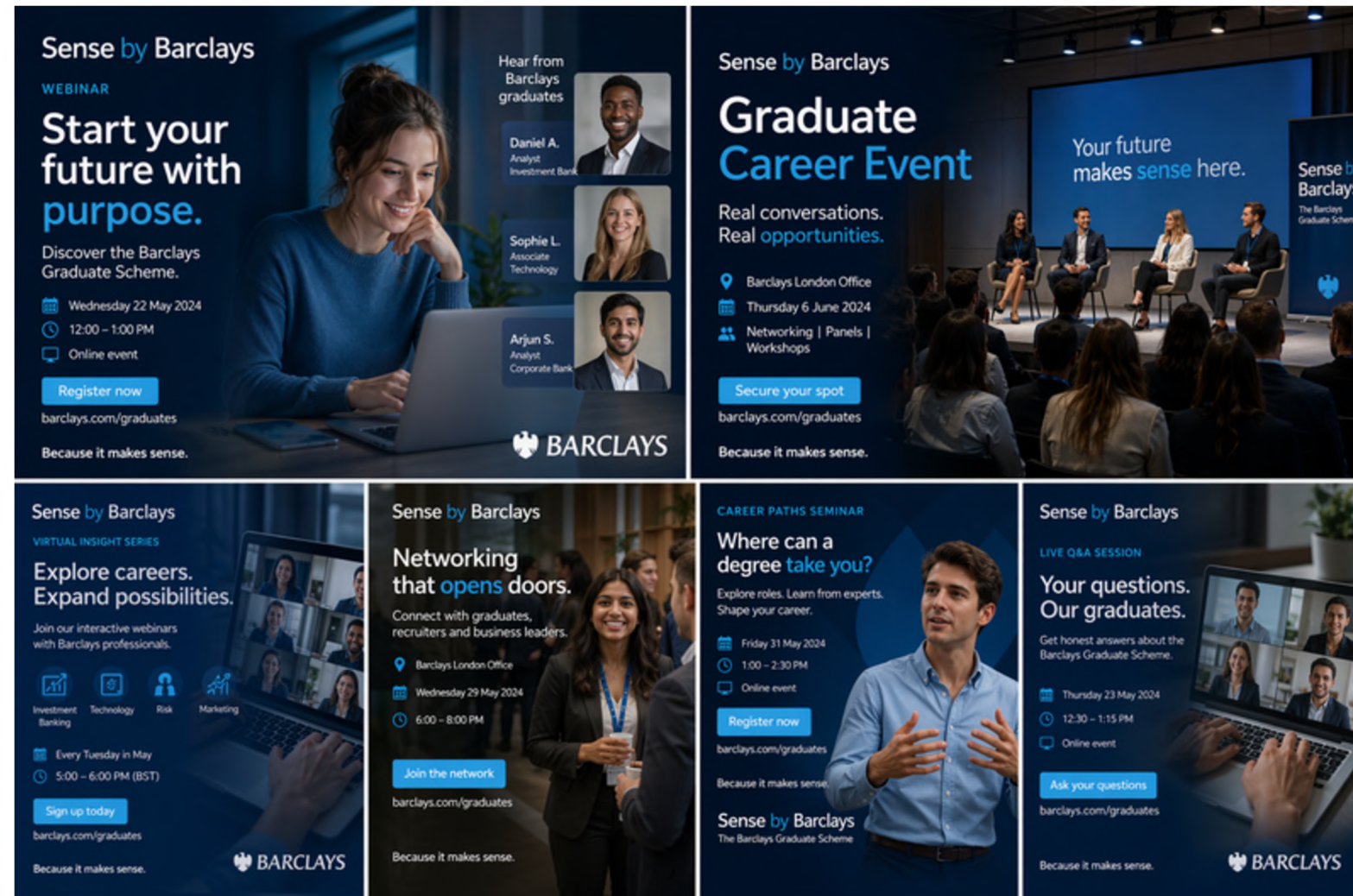
OVERALL PROPOSITION

The Barclays Graduate Scheme campaign combines digital marketing, offline visibility, and experiential networking to create a strong graduate-focused ecosystem. By engaging students online, supporting awareness offline, and building personal connections through networking events, Barclays positions itself as a modern, trustworthy, and logical career choice for graduates.

SENSE IN ACTION

The Sense app experience brings the campaign promise into everyday banking. Instead of presenting graduates with generic account information, it turns financial data into clear, useful actions that help users feel more in control of their money.

Through personalised spending insights, real-time alerts, and reward-led engagement, Sense supports graduates during key financial moments such as receiving their first salary, paying rent, managing bills, and building better money habits.



Understand

Clear spending breakdowns help graduates see where their money is going and identify areas where they can save.

Act

Real-time alerts and prompts provide timely guidance, helping users make better decisions before financial pressure builds.

Benefit

Blue Rewards and behaviour-based incentives encourage regular usage and make Barclays feel valuable beyond sign-up.

Sense turns Barclays from a bank graduates open once into a financial companion they use every day.

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